FIELD TRAINING



CONTRACTING 101

What every foreman should know about contracts, changes, quality and field records

Civil Construction • Site Foreman Briefing

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What Is a Contract, Really?

An agreement to complete a defined scope of work for an agreed method of payment. There are three common payment methods.



Unit Rate

Paid for measured quantities completed.

e.g. **300 mm storm sewer at $450/m**



Lump Sum

Paid an agreed amount for the full scope.

e.g. **$250,000 for site servicing**



Time & Material

Paid for documented labour, equipment and materials used.

e.g. **Crew hrs, excavator hrs, material cost**

HOW THE PRICE IS BUILT

Estimators price every activity from historical production rates, labour, equipment, materials and subcontractor costs. That estimate becomes the baseline for production, cost and margin.

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OUR JOB

Meet or beat that baseline.

Change Order or Claim?

A potential change is anything that may affect the planned scope, cost, production or schedule.



Change Order

A written authorization confirming an agreed change to scope, price, time, or any combination.



Claim

A formal request for additional money or time when responsibility, entitlement, value or schedule impact remains unresolved.

HOW TO RECOGNIZE A CHANGE

1 **Direction**

The client directs the work differently than planned.

2 **Conditions**

Actual site or ground conditions differ from what was estimated.

3 **Delay by Others**

Another party delays or disrupts the work.

If you see one of these, say something. That's step one.

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Five Steps, Starting the Moment You Notice

1. RECOGNIZE

You spot a difference from the plan

IMMEDIATELY

2. NOTIFY

Tell your super or PM, and the inspector or GC rep

IMMEDIATELY

3. RECORD

Capture labour, equipment, materials, quantities, direction, names, photos

SAME SHIFT

4. REVIEW

PM checks it against the estimate, drawings and notice terms

WITHIN 24 HRS

5. RESOLVE

Written authorization comes back, or it's escalated as a claim

PER CONTRACT

Notification rule: Tell someone verbally the moment you see it. Confirm it in writing before the shift ends.

Notice periods vary by contract. Follow your project's actual terms and delegated authority. If you're not sure, notify your super or PM immediately. An on-site alert is not a substitute for formal contractual notice.

FROM THE FIELD

A crew hit rock that wasn't in the geotech. Nobody flagged it, the operator just worked around it and kept going. Three weeks later, at billing time, there's nothing to point to: no notice, no photos, no hours tied to it. The company eats the cost, and the crew that did the extra work never gets credit for it.

That's the difference five minutes of notes makes.

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The Five-Hour Question

Plan: 20 m in 10 hours Actual: 10 m in 10 hours Planned rate: 2 m/hour

5

HOURS ACCOUNTED

10 m installed at the planned rate

5

HOURS TO EXPLAIN

What happened?

POSSIBLE REASONS

- Ground conditions
- Utility conflict
- Client direction
- Inspection wait
- Third-party delay
- Breakdown
- Material shortage
- Crew performance

The missing five hours have to be understood and documented. That's how we determine whether the cost is recoverable, manageable, or ours.

TAKEAWAY

You need to spend money to make money. We just have to be able to show it.

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Rework Costs More Than the Repair

Deficiency

Work that doesn't meet the drawings, specs, approved plan or required quality standard.

Rework

The labour, equipment, materials and time it takes to correct deficient work.

THE TRUE COST OF REWORK

1. Expose or remove completed work
2. Correct, rebuild or replace it
3. Pay for replacement materials and disposal
4. Repeat inspection and testing
5. Lose production on other payable work

Rework consumes project resources without creating any new payable work.

> ***"Whether you like them or not, the inspector is your best friend."***

Inspector acceptance supports the project record. The contractor remains responsible for quality.

USE THE RELATIONSHIP

Before a hold point

Confirm what must be witnessed, tested or measured.

Before covering work

Get the required inspection, measurements and photos.

When directed

Record who gave the direction, what changed, and when.

When deficient

Fix it while the crew and equipment are still on site.

Civil example: an invert at the wrong elevation means excavate, rebuild, retest and backfill, and still zero new payable manholes.

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Record It Before It's Underground

A complete field record connects the work you did to quantities, billing, changes and closeout.

Daily Site Records

Use the approved daily reporting system for the job. If one isn't in place yet, use a daily email template.

- Crew names & hours
- Work location & installed qty
- Weather & site conditions
- Delays, directions, changes
- Equipment & operating hours
- Materials delivered & used
- Inspections, testing, results
- Supporting photographs

Complete the record the same day. Be factual, specific, measurable.

Drawing Markups

Markups show what was actually installed, not just what the original drawing called for.

- Installed location
- Elevations & inverts
- Connections & structures
- Dimensions & offsets
- Pipe size & material
- Approved field changes

Work done › **Daily record + markup** › Quantities verified › Billing & handover

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What a Good Daily Actually Looks Like

Actuals: what the crew, equipment and materials actually used. Not what was planned or budgeted.

WEAK

"Hit rock. Lost time."

Doesn't say where, when, how long, who was told, or what it cost. Nothing here can be billed, defended, or even learned from.

STRONG

"Crew at Sta 10+240 to 10+255 hit rock ~1.2 m below grade, not shown in the geotech. Excavator and 3-person crew stood by 10:15 to 11:05 while super and GC rep were notified. Photos taken before removal. Resumed 11:05 with excavator and breaker."

Every strong entry answers: where, when, who, how long, why, and what happened next.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE SITE

- Crew & hours
- Equipment hours
- Quantity & location
- Delays & reason
- Photos
- Markup updated
- Super notified

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WHAT CHANGES NOW

Three things, starting today



Notice it out loud

See a difference from the plan? Tell your super or PM, and the inspector or GC rep, immediately. Confirm it in writing before the shift ends.



Write it down, same shift

Crew, hours, quantities, conditions, photos. If it isn't documented, it's difficult to prove, price or defend.



Loop in the inspector

Before it's covered up, get it witnessed. It protects your work and the company's, both.

This isn't extra work. It's how the work you're already doing gets recognized and protected.

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